January 17, 1998

RECORD

This Is Not New Zealand

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Sanitarium Feeds College Students

The Sanitarium Health Food Company (Sanitarium) provided breakfast for 450 students and staff the Broadford (Vic) Secondary College on November 10, last year.

Classes were suspended for 30 minutes so all students and staff could participate. "Even the b drivers and the local press tucked into the Sanitarium products," says college curriculum coordinat Allan Gray (who is also a member of the Greensborough church).

Sanitarium sales representative Jason Smith talked to the students about the benefits of a nutritio breakfast, and highlighted the need for them to be aware of the nutrition information (particular sugar and fat content) listed on packets. Mr Smith also helped run a Weet-Bix eating race, and ga away Sanitarium posters, T-shirt prizes, Wallace and Gromit figurines and Don Bradman cricket card

"The breakfast was a resounding success and served several needs," says Mr Gray. "It was fun a educational. It also introduced many young consumers to Sanitarium products and encouraged them adopt healthier lifestyles."

The Sanitarium breakfast was part of a local Uniting Church breakfast program. The church h been providing breakfast at the college two days a week since April last year. About 85 students we turning up regularly.

Pictured is the winner of the Weet-Bix eating race (and Broadford Secondary College mat teacher), Elaine Beedall.

Encouraging the Thinkers

I met Mr and Mrs B at a church camp recently. Great couple, but with some very different points of view. This is what I learned about the two.

She reads devotional books in her spare time; he reads the Bible for two hours every morning. She likes *The Message*; he likes the King James Version. She mentions things in passing; he sits and tells. She thinks Adventists are right most of the time; he thinks they're right all of the time.

Mr and Mrs B's relationship shows there's room in the Adventist Church for all sorts of thinkers—maturing thinkers, free thinkers, deep thinkers. But is the church doing all it can to encourage thinkers?

Some Adventists were asked about Sabbath school Bible-study classes recently. Their responses were published in a special Sabbath school edition of the *Record*.

One said: "I hate it when teachers trot out trivial, low-level type questions that fairly beg for pat answers. I want my thinking to be challenged for a change."

Another: "Why don't teachers teach? Why do they think they have to preach all the time? Don't they think we have anything to say, or do they just keep talking because they feel threatened when we air our opinions?"

What is so threatening about different opinions? Is there something wrong with our doctrines or something damaging about our church that might be uncovered by a thinker or two?

I've found the more I challenge myself, the more I'm confirming what the church teaches. This isn't surprising, but I still have to find out. The process is as important as the result.

The story of Nicodemus shows there's a place in the church for thinkers.

Nicodemus, a teacher who was a member of the highest Jewish religious body, the Sanhedrin, met Jesus *late at night*. Why? Because he had a reputation to protect. A highly qualified teacher and leader was asking a man with no formal education and no official permission to teach, whether or not he was going to heaven.

There's room in the Adventist Church for all sorts of thinkers—maturing thinkers, free thinkers, deep thinkers.

Jesus, who didn't have to worry about protecting his reputation, tried to meet Nicodemus's needs by patiently outlining the essentials necessary for salvation, and His mission.

The essentials for salvation?

"This is how much God loved the world: He gave his Son, his one and only Son. And this is why: so that no-one need be destroyed; by believing in him, anyone can have a whole and lasting life" (John 3:16, *The Message*).

Jesus' mission?

"God didn't go to all the trouble of sending his Son merely to point an accusing finger, telling the world how bad it was. He came to help, to put the world right again" (John 3:17, *The Message*).

Never again in all His earthly ministry did Jesus so clearly explain why He came to earth and how to get to heaven.

But Nicodemus didn't respond immediately to what Jesus had said. He left that night without making any sort of commitment. He was thinking. He wanted to determine for himself whether what Jesus had said was true.

It must have been. At a later time Nicodemus defended Jesus, even if hesitantly, before the Sanhedrin.

Then, after Jesus died on the cross, Nicodemus came (with Joseph of Arimathea) *in broad daylight* to take the body down, wrap it in linen and spices and place it in a tomb.

What a change!

Jesus didn't push Nicodemus. He didn't keep pestering him to accept Him as his Saviour. He left him alone to think.

Nicodemus ended up being a great supporter of Jesus because, in his search for the unchanging essentials for salvation, he kept questioning and challenging what he believed.

Some advice for the modern-day thinker: Don't get frustrated because the church doesn't easily welcome thinkers. Learn to live with unsatisfactory answers (most organisations move well behind their thinkers), but keep asking questions.

It's the thinkers who help Christianity become reality.

Brenton Stacey

Official Paper
South Pacific Division

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Next Week:

Inside the Muslim mind.

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In God's Hands

by Mikelle Ford

My world came crashing down around me.

And it shouldn't have. I'd just been accepted into nursing at university, been happily married for four months and planning a skiing holiday in New Zealand for winter. That's when the doctor informed me that I wasn't sick from overeating at Christmas, but I was two months pregnant.

No! Children weren't meant to be in the picture for another five years.

Tears flowed freely as Mum escorted and supported me out to the car and my waiting husband. He took the news very well, which helped me dry my tears.

Mum and Dad were ecstatic—a grandchild; they couldn't wait. My main comfort was a litre tub of Sara-Lee ultra-chocolate ice-cream.

Then I was drawn to the verse, "In all things give thanks." I wasn't thankful for this. My life had been turned upside down, and I was vomiting every morning and light-headed during the day.

Twelve weeks along and I had my first antenatal visit with a midwife at a local Brisbane hospital. By this stage I was actually excited about the pregnancy.

My ultrasound was booked in at 20 weeks—just before Easter. I looked forward to visiting my grandparents in Sydney on the Anzac Day long weekend and showing them the pictures of my developing baby.

But a week before Easter my nana had a stroke and, after a few days in hospital, she slipped away. Her funeral was planned for the same day as my ultrasound. I yearned to go to her funeral and say my goodbyes. Then, as the scan began, I felt guilty as I was overcome with joy and excitement to see I had a perfect, developing baby inside me.

The drama wasn't over. On the eve of Nana's funeral, my grandfather was rushed to hospital with extreme stomach cramps. He had a ruptured aorta. He was given the choice of an operation with a small chance of survival, or being dead in the morning. The surgeon was pleased with his progress after the operation.

We—Mum, my husband and I—went down to Sydney to be at Pop's bedside. Was this frail, thin, pale man my grandfather? Yes! And I loved him as much as ever. Even with his pain and sorrow he was telling his corny jokes and showing us just how much he loved us, as always. As he spoke of Nana he choked up and tears welled in his eyes. I'd never seen him like that before. Our hearts went out to him and we fought back our tears together.

Mum lived by his bedside that weekend, and a couple of days after our return he was transferred to a rehabilitation centre—he was recovering! Or so it seemed. Five days later he was rushed back to hospital. This time they could do nothing.

We were devastated, especially Mum. Both her parents were gone within a month. While she didn't question God, and while we know He has laid them to rest until the glorious day when He will come again, the pain and emptiness remains.

But wait . . . I had a new life growing within me. I was six months pregnant, stretching ever bigger and feeling a lot of movement within. I couldn't help but share what was happening with my family.

One day at work I was feeling the hurt that comes with losing a loved one, and my heart was going out to my poor mum, when it hit me. God had given me this life—this growing joy—to fill the emptiness within our hearts.

God can see the future and knows the right doors to open for us. Although my mum misses her parents, her days are filled with the laughter and smiles (and crying) from her little granddaughter.

Tears still flow as I remember my grandparents. How I long to hug and kiss them, and share stories of their great-granddaughter. But my days are so full of feedings, nappies and wakeful smiles that there isn't much time for sorrow.

My life *has* been turned upside down, my plans thrown overboard and my priorities reorganised. But what a blessing and reassurance we have in knowing God, and knowing He has His hand over all our lives. □

Mikelle Ford writes from Narangba in Queensland.

Children's Puzzles

The *Record*, in keeping with this year's South Pacific Division theme, "Experience the Power of His Word," is launching a new feature for children. Each week, children will be invited to read a Bible passage, complete a puzzle and send it in. In return, they will receive a sticker to place on an "Experience the Power of His Word" Club card (that will be posted after the first puzzle has been sent in). Fifteen stickers earn a Bible puzzle book, 30 a Bible, and a complete set (one for every puzzle in this year's *Record*) a mystery prize. **See page 14 for more information.**

Did You Hear . . . ?

● . . . How members of the **Moruya** (NSW) church collected more than their targeted amount in last year's Adventist Appeal?

Moruya elder **Bert Sheppard** (pictured with his wife, **Iris**) collected money boxes in the shape of the world. Each member took a world and had one year to fill it.

One member charged people an exit fee to leave his home!

● . . . About the ultra-Orthodox rabbi who ruled that virtual pets should fend for themselves on the Jewish Sabbath?

Rabbi Shmuel Eliahu handed down the decision to a Jewish youth who rebelled against allowing his pet to "die" every week.

Rabbi Eliahu ruled the allowance to feed animals on the Sabbath did not extend to the electronic creatures, which need constant handling to survive.

Pacific Islands

Cyclone Damage

Cyclone Osea hit the island of Maupiti, French Polynesia, on November 25, destroying 80 per cent of the houses. Fifteen Adventist houses were destroyed, and the front of the local Adventist church was swept away. "The island looks like it's been shelled," says French Polynesia Mission communication director Marcel Millaud. On the island of Bora Bora, part of the roof of the Adventist youth hall was blown away, and 10 Adventist houses were damaged.

World Church

1000 Protest

More than 1000 people protested the temporary closure of an Adventist outreach program in Almaty, Kazakhstan, on November 16. The protest came after a rented hall used for the meetings was closed by the hall's custodians. "The crowd became very agitated," says Euro-Asia Division spokesperson Barbara Huff. "An Adventist leader told them, 'We're preaching about moral things here. We don't want a demonstration. Please go home peacefully.'" A new hall has been rented and the meetings are continuing.—*ANN*

Leading Educator Contacted by *Signs*

Former Avondale College principal and South Pacific Division (SPD) education director Dr E G McDowell thanks *Signs of the Times* for helping him become an Adventist.

Dr McDowell (pictured, left) said, in an interview with Dr Trevor Lloyd (right) at Avondale College homecoming last year, that his first contact with the church was through *Signs*.

Pastor Laurie Naden, in his second year of ministry (he later became SPD president), left a *Signs* magazine at the Gisborne, New Zealand, home where Dr McDowell was boarding. The two met soon after and began Bible studies.

Former Adventist Elected Governor-General of PNG

The Papua New Guinean (PNG) government recently elected Silas Atopari, a former Adventist, as the country's new Governor-General for the next six years.

Mr Atopari, described as a down-to-earth and hard-working person, said at his appointment: "It would be very difficult for me to change my way of life, because I am an outgoing person who likes people and wants to be with them."

His most recent job was as general-secretary of the 300,000-member Smallholder Coffee Growers Association.

Mr Atopari's appointment is good news for people in the Eastern Highlands Province and for Adventists—he comes from the predominately Adventist village of Kabiufa.

"Mr Atopari is very supportive of the Adventist Church," says PNG Union Mission secretary Pastor Brad Kemp.

"He wants to see a stable and united country in which Papua New Guineans 'stand united,' and in which decisions made by leaders are guided by the grace of God."

News Extra

Bible Polls Well

The Bible is the only book mentioned in a recent *New Zealand Listener* poll. The 100-question poll included one that asked readers to name the book they would most like to take to a desert island. The answer? The Bible.

CHURCH CALENDAR

January 31 Pacific Islands Advancement Offering

This is NORTH NEW ZEALAND

The Polynesian navigator Kupe is credited with the discovery of New Zealand in about AD 950. He named it Aotearoa, the Land of the Long White Cloud. Some 400 years later a migration from his homeland, in the Society Islands, followed his navigational directions to New Zealand.

Geologists will tell you that they came to islands that form a part of the circum-Pacific mobile crustal belt on the crest of an unstable arcuate earth fold. What that means is that there can be earthquakes and volcanic activity.

The first European, the Dutch explorer Abel Tasman, sailed briefly along the west coast of the South Island in 1642. Then James Cook circumnavigated the islands during 1769-70 and took possession of them "for Britain." European settlement began in the 1820s, in the Bay of Islands area.

More than 70 per cent of the population of some 3.7 million live in the North Island, with more than 1 million living in Auckland. Wellington, at the southern tip of the North Island, is the capital.

The official languages are English and Maori, with the Maori language undergoing a revival of recent times.

While New Zealand has a vibrant manufacturing industry, it is better known for its sheep and dairy products. (And New Zealanders, perhaps tired of sheep jokes, are quick to point out that there are more sheep per head of population in Australia than in New Zealand.)

Adventists number about 8600 in the North Island—1 Adventist for every 300 people in the North New Zealand Conference. That's a challenge.

The growing Polynesian population of New Zealand clearly demonstrates it is an island of the Pacific. It has close links to several Pacific nations; some, like Cook Islanders, automatically have New Zealand citizenship. (Polynesians make up some 4 per cent of the population; Maoris 10 per cent.)

There are 75 churches and companies in the conference, and some of the strongest are Polynesian. But they range from the spaciousness of the Papatoetoe church in Auckland to the simplicity of the hired schools some companies meet in.

North New Zealand has an Adventist retirement village and a home for the aged. It has 13 primary schools and a high school. Longburn College (high-school level) is a part of North New Zealand, but it is a Trans-Tasman Union Conference institution, as is the Auckland Adventist Hospital. The Sanitarium Health Food Company is the number one breakfast-food manufacturer in New Zealand and has held that place for several years.

But you will discover that the church in North New Zealand is much more than buildings, statistics and institutions. It's about people trying to make a positive difference. □

Diversity Means Strength

The best thing about the North New Zealand Conference (NNZ) is its diversity, says the conference president, Pastor Bill Townend.

"This conference is multicultural," he says. "You have the *pakeha* churches, you have a number of mixed churches, you have churches of just about every Pacific island country. Then there's a Chinese church and a Korean church.

Pastor Bill Townend.

"Almost 40 per cent of our membership is non-European. And in Auckland, some 60 per cent of our membership attends a non-European church. That might be a language church or it might be a multicultural church."

He adds that in the six years he has served as president, this diversity of membership has not caused any major tensions. The problem it can cause is in finding senior pastors for language churches within the conference.

"We're looking for a senior Samoan pastor for Wellington now because the pastor there is retiring. It's difficult to find a senior man without raiding the [Samoan] mission. I don't like to raid the missions, because they don't need us pulling off their good men."

Samoans are the largest ethnic group of the NNZ church, at about 20 per cent of the church population.

"My view is that within a period of time—10 or 20 years—we won't have language churches, because as the groups stay on for the second and third generation they're less inclined to want language churches."

Church Growth

Most membership growth within the conference is coming from Polynesian groups. But this may not last, says Pastor Townend.

"This Polynesian growth is good and we encourage it, but the longer the Polynesians stay here the more secular they become and the more difficult to win."

And there has been an attempt to bring back Polynesian young people who have left the church with the establishment of Calvary Community Church under Pastor Paul Siope.

"Paul's church was set up as an experimental church for evangelism, but also to attract backslidden Polynesian young people who don't feel comfortable in their language churches—sometimes they don't speak the language. But they don't feel comfortable in a European church. This is about its fourth year and he's having some success, but it's a slow process to win them back."

The biggest challenge within the conference is evangelism among the Europeans. He points to Hamilton church as being a "classic" example of what can be done. He says he feels their success has come from their focus.

The year 1997 has been a good one for growth in NNZ. The final figure for baptisms will be close to 500.

"We have more churches than ever doing some outreach into their community," says Pastor Townend. "That's what's making it happen. I think this has come from a slow process of emphasising the importance of evangelism. They just seem to be catching the vision."

He says the churches are involved in a variety of outreach programs ranging from public evangelism to doctrinal-based prophecy seminars and health seminars.

Schools Integrate

Four years ago the Adventist education system in New Zealand integrated with the state system. Pastor Townend calls this the "most significant thing that has happened to education in this division in the past 50 years." He also calls it a miracle.

"We really gave our schools away, but we retained them," is how he puts it. "The high school owed $NZ600,000 to the conference and it couldn't go on another year. Right at that time, the government changed the integration act so that it was acceptable to us. It was a miracle, because that high school was gone."

In brief, integration has meant: the government has taken over the responsibility of paying teachers' wages; fees have dropped dramatically; local churches no longer have a financial commitment to the schools except through six offerings a year; student numbers have doubled (from 600 to 1200); most schools are full and want new classrooms. Importantly, the government will refuse funding if Adventist schools lose their uniqueness (the NZ Education Department asks, Why should we fund you if you are no different to the government schools?)

Conference funding for schools has not decreased because of their responsibility for maintaining the schools. (An extensive report on New Zealand integration will appear in a future *Record*.)

"The Lord's Blessing"

"The spiritual pulse of the church is quite good," says Pastor Townend. "And again, the Polynesian people help that because they're very committed to the church and are, basically, spiritual people. That helps to keep a very high spiritual tone around the conference.

"And when you have a church that is busy, that has good things happening, usually you'll find a good spiritual tone underpinning it."

Pastor Townend has a primary goal for the North New Zealand Conference: to see it reach 10,000 members by the year 2000. Currently the membership is about 8600.

"I want to see a strong, spiritually based church. And it would be great if our church membership represented the population make-up of society. The Polynesians make only 15 per cent of society, yet they are 40 per cent of the church. I would like to see more growth among our European population.

"This is a good conference. Things are happening. The Lord's blessing." □

Where It All Began

It all started in 1889. The first four churches in New Zealand (Kaeo, then Ponsonby, then Napier, then Gisborne) were organised within a few years of each other, and the New Zealand Conference was born.

Ponsonby church, the site of the oldest Adventist church building in the South Pacific Division, celebrated its 110th year during 1997.

American minister Pastor Arthur Daniells (who later became General Conference president) was the first president of the conference (based in Wellington). It was reorganised into the North New Zealand and South New Zealand Conferences in 1915.

The Hares

Joseph Hare, his sons, Edward and Robert, their families and those influenced by them, formed the Kaeo church in 1886 after being baptised by American pioneer Pastor Stephen Haskell in a mountain stream.

Some were hesitant, however, because they'd heard Adventists required candidates to be baptised naked!

The Hare family went on to become one of the most prominent in Adventist history.

Camp-meetings

The first genuine camp-meeting in New Zealand was held in Napier, in 1893. In earlier meetings, church members were billeted in homes; this time they slept in tents pitched on a site near the present Napier City Library. The visiting speaker was Ellen White.

The next camp-meeting was in Wellington. Organisers raised public interest in the meetings by bringing the Adventist mission ship *Pitcairn* to Port Nicholson, distributing literature before the meetings and organising a community field day.

Schools

The first school in New Zealand was set up in Ponsonby in 1902. It closed 12 months later because of attendance and financial difficulties.

Pastor Arthur Daniells.

Another school was set up in Napier in 1903—tuition was free for church families. The school taught physiology, nature and manual work subjects, and used Ellen White's *Early Writings* in the reading program.

Three other schools followed—Wellington (1904), New Plymouth (1905) and Cambridge (1908).

Maoris

In 1906 evangelist Pastor William Carswell started working with Maoris in the Gisborne area.

Pastor Carswell, a New Zealander who had previously worked in Australia, visited Maori villages, prepared literature in the Maori language and produced a monthly paper called *Te Karere o Te Pono* (The Herald of Truth).

Pastor Carswell was joined by two nurses, Mr and Mrs Reid-Smith, who had graduated from the Sydney Sanitarium. However, Mr Reid-Smith died of typhoid in 1910, and Pastor Carswell returned to Australia because of his wife's prolonged illness. The Maori work soon stopped.

In 1940 however, Pastor Paul Claus (described as having a practical bent) began visiting Maori homes in Te Kao, teaching hygiene and agriculture. This led to the opening of the first Adventist Maori church building in New Zealand. □

The Pioneer

In 1885 American minister Pastor Stephen Haskell visited Auckland on his way to Australia with a pioneering party of Adventist missionaries.

During the four-hour stopover he and his associates explored the city. His lasting impression? The number of libraries.

He reasoned if this were any indication of the standard of literacy, New Zealanders should respond favourably to the reading of the church's literature and to the preaching of the Bible.

The Maori

The influence of an Adventist cook at Te Aute College, a secondary boarding school for Maoris, resulted in a number of students becoming Adventists. One, Maui Pomare, was encouraged to travel to America to train as a medical missionary.

When Mr Pomare returned to New Zealand, he stopped being an active member of the Adventist Church, entered politics, became a Minister for Health, and was ultimately knighted for his service to the Maori people.

The Preacher

Pastor Mendel Israel, a pioneer from Nova Scotia, Canada, was used to rugged weather, but he was frustrated in his evangelistic endeavours by Wellington's famous winds.

"The winds sweeping through Cook Strait make it impossible to pitch the mission tent for any length of time," he once said.

So he moved to Blenheim and then Nelson, becoming the first Adventist minister to preach on the South Island.

Evangelism at Work

During 1997 there has been an emphasis on evangelism in North New Zealand that looks like it will pay off with the largest number of people ever baptised in the conference during one year. There's even the hope that the conference will see 500 baptisms for the year.

"What is really making it happen is that we have more churches this year doing some outreach in their community," said the president of the conference, Pastor Bill Townend, late last year. "They just seem to be catching the vision."

He says that churches were doing a variety of things, from doctrinal-based programs and prophecy seminars to health and soup kitchens.

"It's quite a mix, but the good thing is that they are all doing something.

"Last year we put $NZ250,000 into evangelism," adds the secretary-treasurer, Warrick Long, "which is the most we've ever done. For 1998 we're going to $NZ265,000, if we can."

He says that he had had requests for $NZ500,000 for evangelism, "so a lot of churches got a lot less than what they'd hoped for. But nearly all those programs have still come off."

There are plenty of examples of evangelistic enthusiasm in North New Zealand.

The Church With Focus

Hamilton church is one of the shining lights in the conference, says Pastor Townend. He's referring to its growth (by about 45) over the past two years.

"The plan was to make every aspect of the church mission oriented," says Hamilton pastor Bryan Vickery. "Mission is the key word rather than evangelism. Everything from Ad*Care* to seminars to hospitality—everything had an outreach function. It has been a fairly hectic two years."

In February 1996, the month after he arrived at Hamilton, Adventist Media Centre evangelist Pastor Geoffrey Youlden ran an evangelistic campaign.

"That went well. And as success begets success, the momentum had started thanks

Bryan Vickery.

to a lot of the groundwork by Pastor Jerry Matthews, who prepared the church for the mission program. The church members were keen to embrace mission and outreach as the dominant approach of the church."

During 1996 the church had five seminars running constantly. They used Prophecy Seminar, Daniel Seminar and Revelation Seminar material.

"We had lay people as presenters in order to give them the joy of presenting," says Mr Vickery, "and, because they were the ones running the seminars, they pulled along their supporters."

He also conducted a series of small campaigns himself "because of my interest in evangelism."

"During 1996 we had heaps of these seminars and about six cell groups, so that when the new people left the seminars they were integrated into a cell group. These were still along the lines of a Bible study, but there was more nurture, intercessory prayer and fellowship.

"We attempted to have some of the older Adventists act as mentors of these new converts in the cell groups. We stressed that hospitality also had evangelistic potential."

Added to these programs were health days, cooking demonstrations and outreach programs on the Waikato University campus.

About 30 people were baptised during 1996, all of whom are still in the church, adds Mr Vickery.

During 1997 there has been "less emphasis on big-budget programs" and more reliance on church-member involvement. The seminars are continuing. They expect to have baptised another 15 or so by the end of that year.

The church has also opened a soup kitchen.

"We felt last year [1996] that we were too program oriented, so this year [1997] we wanted to stress that the church also has a compassionate face," says Mr Vickery. "We've been running a successful soup kitchen for about six months. We regularly have between 40 and 70 non-Adventists who not only eat the food, but they hang around for a low-key program on a Friday night.

"And we're actually running a program that is a combination of a soup kitchen and Vacation Bible School, with about 55 non-Adventist young people coming along. It's in a community hall, and the good thing about it is that youth run the program."

He speaks also of the Seventh-day Adventist University Fellowship Club that meets weekly on the university campus. Between 20 and 30 students meet for Bible study and prayer, and a social program.

"I believe the essence of Adventism is mission," he says. "We need to get close to Jesus and prepare people for the Second Coming. If you can get every part of the church focused on mission, it eliminates a lot of the distractions."

Samoan Evangelism Success

For the past three years Dr Erika Puni has run three or four evangelistic campaigns each year among Samoans in North New Zealand with good success. During 1997 he ran six campaigns (including one in South New Zealand and another in Brisbane) with more dramatic results.

His program for the year included:

March: Christchurch—18 baptised, with another five added through the pastor's follow-up work.

April-May: Auckland—60 baptised. This was a Global Mission project that had two objectives: to run a program in an unentered area of Auckland; and to establish a church. The Auckland Central Samoan Company began in August with 20 members and now has more than 40.

May-June: Brisbane—36 baptised in the Springwood church.

June-July: West Auckland—21 baptised.

August-September: Royal Oak (Auckland)—47 baptised

October: Wellington—30 baptised.

As well as conducting campaigns, he is the pastor of the South Auckland Samoan church (of 280 members) and two companies, and the assistant secretary of the conference.

"My church barely sees me once a month when I'm busy with a campaign," says Dr Puni.

"I use archaeology for just a small part of my programs. I use it as part of my introduction for about 10-12 minutes. Then I have the lights on and teach from the Bible."

Each series runs for three weeks and four weekends. He conducts 16 meetings, plus the Sabbaths.

"I want them to come to church on the Sabbaths because it is part of the campaign, but it isn't part of the public meetings," he explains.

Dr Puni is a Samoan and he speaks in Samoan and English during each program because he has discovered people are bringing friends from different ethnic backgrounds. Some of these are being baptised as well.

Dr Erika Puni.

He thinks the reason for the success comes from several factors.

"The first is that there is a yearning for spiritual things. Then, Samoans come from a Bible-based culture—within their culture is a place for religious ideology.

"Consequently, when I use archaeology I use it as a means of leading them from their current Bible knowledge to things they have not seen. It creates an interest."

Those being baptised range from those in their early 20s to the late 50s.

"This is a team effort," says Dr Puni. "There is a good partnership between the local pastor and the members. I come in as their guest. The conference provides some of the funding. It's a partnership."

Dr Puni is the son of the first Samoan pastor in New Zealand. He sees his spiritual gift as evangelism, which has been backed up by his training in missiology and church growth at Fuller Theological Seminary.

At the City Centre

New Plymouth church on the west coast of North New Zealand wanted to develop a presence in town. The church of some 160 members has a school in the area, but wanted something more.

"We prayed that the Lord would lead us to something for some time," says Kevin Robinson, the church pastor.

When a large upstairs area (288 square metres) above the Christian bookshop in the centre of town became available, they began to investigate. The owner of the building became enthusiastic about the concept they presented, and urged them to "do something" for street kids as well. He offered it to them for $NZ600 a month (normally it would rent for $NZ550 a week).

"He could have leased it someone else," says Mr Robinson, "but he has been so pleased with our work that for the next few months he is charging us only $NZ400 a month."

They began to use the centre in April 1997. The area consists of two large rooms with four smaller offices coming off them. One of the smaller rooms is set up as a children's playroom and video lounge. Another is a small Adventist Book Centre (the church staffs the ABC for free and the ABC pays the phone bill for the centre). Another room is an interview or small seminar room. The fourth is for storage.

The first woman elder of the Otara church (a Cook Island church), Mrs N Poko, is pictured with her granddaughter.

One of the larger rooms is set up to sell second-hand clothing. The other is a drop-in centre.

"All types drop in. Sometimes they drop in for free hot drinks, some come in for chat. We even had one woman who took a *Great Controversy* and came back wanting another for her daughter. That kind of thing wouldn't happen if we didn't have a presence there."

The centre is used to run Quit *Now!* programs, parenting programs and vegetarian cooking classes. Every second Saturday night 20-25 children come for a games evening.

Church members volunteer their time to staff the centre from 10 am to 4 pm Monday to Friday. Mostly, it isn't difficult to find volunteers.

During 1998 the church plans to run a Sabbath afternoon or Sunday program in the centre about basic Christianity. From that they will offer small groups and lead into the NET '98 evangelistic program at the end of the year.

"The presence in town has been really helpful," says Mr Robinson, "and there has been a bonding of church members as they've worked together."

The only downside seems to be that it is currently not paying for itself. "But we're looking at avenues of having it do that," he adds. □

A report concerning the Adventist Church's work among Maoris in New Zealand will appear later in the year.

NNZ Leads the Way

Ask Warrick Long the best thing about his job and he answers quickly: "Waking up and saying, 'Hey, I get to go and do it all again.' I love doing what I do.

"It's exciting to be a part of a conference, and the best thing about North New Zealand is probably the fact that we've turned a corner. We're moving forward. That's evident in our evangelism and our school system. We've got problems; things happen that you don't like. But look at the big picture—the big picture looks real exciting for us."

Warrick Long.

Maybe the enthusiasm comes from his age. He's one of the youngest secretary-treasurers in the South Pacific Division.

"I was 30 when I hit here, and that's been, at times, a disadvantage because you just don't have the experience. You make mistakes. But you learn.

"I believe enthusiasm helps because sometimes people will forgive you your foibles for your enthusiasm."

And there seems to be plenty for a secretary-treasurer to be enthusiastic about. Baptisms are at the highest they have ever been for any 12-month period. And, for the first time, in 1996, tithe exceeded $NZ5 million, and is expected to be higher in 1997.

"We went through a horrific patch in the early '90s when tithe took a considerable dive and we had to be bailed out by the division, but we've picked ourselves up and we're going for it."

He does have a concern that the conference has the lowest tithe per capita in the Trans-Tasman Union Conference. And that, he says, limits the level of services the conference can give. He's currently campaigning for more faithful tithe paying, because he can see from census figures the church receives only about half the tithe that should be paid.

"I'm unhappy with this for two reasons: First, there's a constant demand on resources. The churches want more pastors and more visitation. I can provide that only if I have resources to do it. I think it immoral if people sit in a pew and consume resources without contributing.

"Second, it shows that there are 50 per cent of those who call themselves Adventists aren't faithful to a very clear biblical principle. That has repercussions for them in the long term.

"I've asked all church boards and the pastors what we can do, and also asked them to keep it before the people. It needs to be addressed from the local level as well."

He sees the growth among the Polynesian churches as a positive thing, but has a theory that "doesn't win me a lot of friends" about a major reason for their success compared to European churches.

"When the Polynesian church goes into an evangelistic program, the whole community becomes a part of it. In Wellington the whole Wellington Samoan Adventist community attended the program there. In Auckland, all the Auckland Samoan Adventist churches got behind that program and promoted it. Among our European churches, we tend to operate as isolated islands."

Adventist schools in North New Zealand are bringing both joy and pain. The schools are booming.

"How do we fund the growth of the school system? We've got schools that want to keep growing. It's exciting."

And in five years time he hopes that the conference is doing more of what it's doing, "if North New Zealand hasn't finished the work first."

"It's going to be North New Zealand that leads the way," he says. □

The ABC That Advertised

The Adventist Book Centre (ABC) in Auckland has just re-signed a contract with Radio Rhema to run advertising. Trial advertising has seen an increase in sales, and 70-80 per cent of "walk-in" sales are now going to non-Adventists.

Gavin Howie finds that advertising brings sales to the ABC.

"A lot of non-Adventist pastors shop here," says the ABC manager, Gavin Howie, "and pass the information on to their parishioners. A lot of the more conservative pastors and churches know our reputation for choosing theologically correct publications and also good quality Christian music.

"I've actually had young people come in here and say that they know our reputation about our music and they have confidence in what we have."

While most sales are by mail order, the shop (which is at the conference office in Manukau City, an outer suburb of Auckland) has an average of about 30 customers a day. They also have growing worldwide mail-order sales.

Active Youth Program

With almost half the Adventist population of North New Zealand in the youth age group, the two youth leaders for the conference are kept busy.

"The good thing about the youth program here is that when we run a program, we have an audience we can talk to," says the youth director, Pastor Gervais Cangy.

He and the assistant youth director, Pastor Lloyd Grolimund, say that New Zealand youth are very responsive to youth events.

"We're quite thrilled that at anytime, with a program that is well promoted, you can get 1000 young people there," says Pastor Cangy. And he adds that it's the same whether it happens in Auckland or in the south at Palmerston North.

"What does give us some sort of a thrill is that a good percentage of the people baptised are young people. At the last camporee we held, in January last year, 280 young people asked for baptism."

"We had a youth convention not too long ago where we had 26 young people take a stand, some for baptism, some for rebaptism. Most of those requesting rebaptism were *pakeha* kids who had been in the church, but for some reason had fallen out. A few of them now are at Avondale College. This was a life-changing experience for them."

Pastor Gervais Cangy.

Because there is strong support for youth events, the Youth Department plans a youth evangelistic series in Auckland during 1998.

One of the strong programs running for youth are basketball tournaments—run by the youth. They're planned so that the Sabbath of the tournament is a major spiritual day. Teams come from as far away as the South Island to compete and be a part of the weekend.

Start talking about the youth scene in Auckland and you soon hear about Friday Night Live, a monthly program being run at Papatoetoe church.

Students from Auckland Adventist High School.

"At times they have more people on Friday night than on the Sabbath," says Pastor Cangy. "Then there's Calvary Community Church, which was set up to target the New Zealand–born Polynesians. Calvary is even one step beyond Friday Night Live, in terms of what is offered. They minister and reach out to the secular people out there."

Pastor Lloyd Grolimun

However they are ministered to, the need among the youth is still the same: "The greatest need I see is for young people to experience the real Jesus Christ," says Pastor Grolimund. □

Youth Camp Use Varies

Andrew West points to where he thinks some church boards should go to learn to work together.

The North New Zealand youth camp Tui Ridge Park is situated near Rotorua, and is gaining a good reputation among Christian and government organisations for its work. Often you'll find disadvantaged children enjoying the facilities—something that is funded by organisations outside the church.

A recent development is team-building equipment, which is being used by corporate groups. It's also being used to help youth with social problems to regain their self-confidence. The tasks the individuals are asked to do look frightening, but are quite safe with the support of others.

"We've never had an accident on any of this equipment," says Andrew West, one of those who instruct people through the equipment.

"I'd like to get some church boards up on those wires," he quips, pointing to what looks like a tightrope some 15 metres above the ground. "That would teach them how to get on."

The manager of Tui Ridge Park (until the end of 1997), Pastor Wayne Gredig, hopes that more contracts can be made with outside groups. He feels, though, that the camp is not yet used to its full potential by church groups.

Schools Encouraged to Win

Hawkes Bay Adventist Primary School in Napier is full—"bursting at the seams," is how the principal, Kevin Judge, puts it. That's typical of Adventist schools in New Zealand since the introduction of integration with the government.

The government now pays the wages of all teachers. This means fees are down to about a quarter of what they were before integration, making them more affordable to parents. (A full report on integration in New Zealand, including strengths and weaknesses, will appear in a later issue of the *Record*.)

The Hawkes Bay school was recently renovated and painted. The new paint along the hallway is bright yellow.

"This is where kids live," says Mr Judge, explaining the colour.

Almost 100 children attend the school, and the number of non-Adventist children is high. It's the only Christian school in Napier, and it has been adopted by people from several denominations as their school. Mr Judge is keen to see the school grow to about 150, and he says it has the potential if they can have another two classrooms.

This is where it becomes difficult for the conference, because it is responsible for paying for classrooms and benefits to the teachers.

"The government pays wages, we pay additional benefits," says the conference treasurer, Warrick Long. "That's eating up about 10 per cent of tithe again, and it's growing. But some of our schools are doing a great job in working with those kids. The Hawkes Bay school has an evangelism program. Three families have been baptised as a result of their kids being there. That's what it is all about. That's brilliant!"

But there is a limit to what the conference can fund.

"Our executive committee has taken an action saying that they will support growth only where the waiting list is predominately Adventist," says the conference president, Pastor Bill Townend. "We have some schools that are more than 90 per cent non-Adventist."

Kevin Judge sees Adventist schools being on target for growth.

But there is another message the schools also get: "We say to them, when you have a program of evangelism in place we'll consider more funding," says Mr Long.

Mr Judge talks about the evangelistic potential of his school. In Napier's case, the school is on an adjoining property to the church and the link is quite strong. Once a year the school takes the church program, which, he says, breaks down barriers.

Auckland Adventist High School reports a similar story of growth.

"We certainly have more Adventists in the school than we had three years ago, but we also have more Methodist, Catholic and Church of England students as well," says the principal, Gavin Williams.

"The non-Adventist students come here and their parents know that Saturday is our Sabbath, we have certain health principles, we interpret the Bible in certain ways and that's the way it will be. And if they want their child here they must be prepared for the fact that their child may want to be Adventist, and some of them do.

"One Tongan boy who attended here a few years ago is now regularly attending a Tongan Adventist church, and I asked the parents how they felt about that. They said, 'Fine, because he is worshipping the Lord, but if he hadn't come to your school we doubt he would be a Christian at all.'"

At Auckland Adventist High School, 60 students are in Bible-study classes. Some are there just for the study, but some are preparing for baptism. A number of them come from non-Adventist homes.

"If our schools are centres of evangelism and outreach, surely, in terms of the value for the dollar you're putting in, it's a good way to go," adds Mr Williams.

He talks about attending the Tongan Mizpah church, a church of 100 near the school where 10 students assisted him in taking the worship service. Half the students weren't Adventists, but several gave their testimony and promoted Adventist education. Several members of their families were there.

"This is positive. We did the same at Penrose the other week. I had the non-Adventists get up and promote Adventist education to Adventist parents. A lot of the Adventists were quite touched, because they spoke in perfect Tongan. They knew they were attending the Adventist schools and they were giving a testimony about how good this Adventist school was and that they'd better get their kids into this school."

Auckland Adventist High School principal Gavin Williams.

He sees his school having a special Adventist character that is helping youth—Adventist and non-Adventist—develop spiritually. □

"This Is North New Zealand" was prepared by Bruce Manners and Brenton Stacey. "Where It All Began" was adapted from the chapters "New Zealand" (Ross Goldstone) and "Church Schools" (Trevor Lloyd) from the book (Noel Clapham, ed), Seventh-day Adventists in the South Pacific: 1885-1985, Signs Publishing Company, Warburton, Victoria, 1985.

Quotable

"I'm tired of the continual complaining about today's youth. It isn't their fault they've turned out the way they have!"—*Pearl Lambert, ACT*

On Our Youth

IN THE QUIET OF A BEAUTIFUL SABBATH afternoon, I read "Youth: The Church Faces a Crisis" (November 8). It brought to mind what a neighbour said to me as we chatted in her plant nursery.

"We have known a lot of your church members over the years. We've seen their children grow up; we've seen them leave the church, but, as the years have rolled along, we've seen many of them return to it, bringing their little ones with them. Your church gives a sound platform on which to build."

I turned a few more pages of *Record* and read "Baptisms." The names of Carrie, Samantha and Tim jumped out at me. These dear young teenagers are my twin brother's children. What a lovely surprise! May God bless them all, our dear, young people.

God knows where they are, even if we've lost track.

Jean Bakker, Vic

Woe Unto the Weaklings

I'M TIRED OF THE CONTINUAL COMplaining about today's youth. It isn't their fault they've turned out the way they have! If anyone is to blame, it's their parents. Today's youth have been badly spoilt. And simply put, spoiling creates weaklings.

The baby-boomer generation was the first to be spoilt. Their parents' attitude was/is: "We had a rough time during the Depression and World War II, so our children aren't going to have the same thing happen to them."

The harvest? The next generation is even more spoilt, which means even greater weaklings.

Jesus, in His mercy, does not spoil us. He continually puts us through a grilling to ensure that we grow strong, healthy, upright characters, fit for the kingdom.

I would like to suggest that we have only ourselves to blame. There is no effort required to adopt the easy way. I'm eternally grateful that Jesus took the hard way, as He could have so easily forsaken death on the cross.

Why don't parents take a leaf out of His Book?

Pearl Lambert, ACT

Totally Appropriate

AFTER READING "INAPPROPRIATE RESponse" (November 1), We went back to the letter to the Queen in the *Record* of September 27.

We praised the Lord for a president, who, even though he has constituents like "Name Withheld," was prepared to act in a Christian and sympathetic way on behalf of our church.

If the letter failed to represent the constituency of the church, then pity help a church that doesn't have feelings for the loss of a greatly loved and respected person such as Princess Diana. The loss of Diana was made all the more devastating because of the humanitarian aspect of her work.

Can't we give praise where praise is due?

Ralph and Enid Rayner, Qld

Help Wanted

I'M WORKING ON A FULL-TIME, NONpaying research project on the literature and philosophy of healing. Can any *Record* readers help me by providing any of the following?

1. Any health books, medical texts or references (ancient, classical, medieval, futuristic, occidental, oriental, conventional or idealistic), no matter what their state.

2. Any published or first-hand accounts of healing services, conditions and costs anywhere in the world.

3. Personal answers to the question: "What do you see as the 20th-century and 21st-century application of Ellen White's 19th-century health teachings, or of the 19th-century 'hygienic' system of healing?"

4. Is there a medical academic anywhere who is prepared to act as my PhD supervisor, in association with the Head of the School of Language, Literature and Communication, at James Cook University?

Anyone prepared to assist me with fulfilling these requests can contact me at "Bellthorpe" via Woodford, Queensland 4514.

Jane Hunt, Qld

Mail: *Record* Editor, Signs Publishing Company, Warburton Victoria 3799 **E-mail:** CompuServe 74617,726; Internet 74617.726@compuserve.com **Fax:** (03) 5966 9019

Views in Letters do not necessarily represent those of the editors or the denomination. Letters should be less than 250 words, and writers must include their name, address and telephone number.

EXPERIENCE the Power of His Word

This year, 1998, is the year to *Experience the Power of His Word*. As such there will be a special feature for the younger generation each week in the RECORD. There will be a Bible passage to read and a puzzle to complete. All puzzles will be based on the New International Version of the Bible.

We would like to encourage the younger people of our church to *Experience the Power of His Word*, and as such we invite all those who are school age to send in their completed puzzles after they have read the Bible passage suggested.

Each puzzle received will be returned with a sticker to place on a special *Experience the Power of His Word* Club card (a club card will be posted to each person after the first puzzle has been sent in). On collecting 15 stickers, a Bible puzzle book will be sent out; 30 stickers, a Bible; a complete set of stickers, a mystery prize.

Parents of preschool children who would like them to join the *Experience the Power of His Word* Club, may send in one of their child/ren's drawings highlighting the main points of the Bible reading for the week (some of these may even be published).

Some of the puzzles will be really easy; others will be quite difficult. Parents are allowed to help!

Special Bible passage to read for this week: Genesis 1-2

Creation

The following text is written in code. Can you break the code to find the text in Genesis 1?

Clue: ♏ = e

Text: .....

.....

Name: ..... Age: .....

Address: .....

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G Edward Reid is director of stewardship for the North American Division. He is an ordained minister and licensed attorney.

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JANUARY BOOK OF THE MONTH

Obituaries

Love, Rita (nee Dumble), born 21.2.26 in Yorkshire, England; died 14.6.97 in Adelaide Hospital, SA. She migrated to Tasmania in 1936. She became an Adventist with the help of her workmate, Jean Fisher (nee Fehlberg), and was baptised in the Moonah church in the early 1940s. She worked at the Signs Publishing Company for a short time, and in 1952 she married Keith at the Kensington Adventist church, SA. She is survived by her husband; children, Jenny and Graeme Barker (Eight Mile Plains, Qld), Glenda and Wayne Mines (Adelaide, SA); grandchildren, Kirillee, Matthew and Lauren; and sister, Marjorie McCallum (Bellerive, Tas).

K Love, G Olson

McGaw, William Reginald, born 6.1.22 at Toongabbie, NSW; died 22.3.97 at Westmead Hospital. He served his country in World War II in New Guinea and Borneo. He was married to Mavis Blanchard on 14.12.48 at North Sydney by Pastor V Wood-Stotesbury. He is survived by his wife (Wentworthville); children, Lyn Katschke (Ballina), Glenda Nugara (Baulkham Hills) and David (Schofields); and seven grandchildren.

Roger Goven

Advertisements

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Medical Practitioner for Sopas Adventist Hospital. Sopas Adventist Hospital requires the services of a full-time medical practitioner in Papua New Guinea from June 1998. Applications close February 6, 1998. Suitable applicants would be expected to have background experience in general medicine, surgery, anaesthetics or obstetrics, or a mixture of these disciplines. The workload is shared with other medical staff, while development of expertise and skills in a mission hospital setting provides benefits for the 250,000 people who depend on Sopas as their referral hospital. Sopas has a history of more than 30 years as a mission hospital and has the highest level nursing training program in PNG. The hospital is recognised and supported by the government as the provincial hospital for Enga. To obtain information on employment conditions, remuneration and leave packages, interested medical practitioners should in the first instance contact the Associate Secretary of the South Pacific Division, or the Adventist Health Director, at 148 Fox Valley Road, Wahroonga 2076, by fax (02) 9489 0943, or phone on (02) 9847 3333.

PhD Scholarship in Food Technology available to a suitable student with good BSc (honours). Sponsored by Sanitarium. Contact Dr Bob Hosken, Department of Food Technology, University of Newcastle. Phone (02) 4348 4128 or firwh@cc.newcastle.edu.au

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Contact Pastor Eric White, Coordinator Volunteer Services, South Pacific Division, 148 Fox Valley Road, Wahroonga NSW 2076. Phone (02) 9847 3333 or fax (02) 9489 0943. E-mail address: 74617.3462@compuserve.com or Pam_Pedder/SDASPD%notesgw.compuserve.com

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.....

..... Postcode .....

Please post your application and sponsorship money to:

FREEPOST 9
Asian Aid Organisation Ltd
PO Box 333
Wauchope, NSW 2446

FREEPOST 65046
Asian Aid Organisation Ltd
PO Box 7090
Palmerston North, New Zealand

Payments may be made by credit card through FREEPOST or by phone on (02) 6587 6196.

Bankcard ☐ MasterCard ☐ Visa ☐ Expiry Date ..... Amount .....

Card No ☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐

This payment is to be ☐ a regular monthly payment ☐ one single payment

Card Name ..... Signature .....

ASIAN AID ORGANISATION LTD
ACN 002 286 419

All donations over $2.00 are tax-deductible in Australia.

A begger girl and sibling on the streets of Bombay, India.

We know how important it is for our children to have a good education. We do our best to make sure they have a clean uniform and well-fitting shoes. The backpacks are stocked with the necessary exercise books, pens and pencils needed to start the new year.

But in some poor areas of India and Bangladesh many children do not have the same opportunity. Even if there were a school for them to go to, they would not be able to afford a pair of shoes to wear, much less a uniform.

As you prepare your children for this new school year, please consider how little it really costs to provide an education to one of these children. Sponsorships range between $10 and $30 per month.

In very poor areas the schools may have a meal plan that provides students with a hot midday meal. Sometimes this may be the major source of food for them, as the parents often struggle to find enough to feed the family even one meal each day.

Through **Asian Aid** you can choose to be the means through whom God is able to show His love to these illiterate children.

For as little as $10 a month you can provide an education for a village child.

Please contact Helen or Kerryn at Asian Aid today, and tell them of your decision to educate a child.